European communist leaders used to do. Besides, Khrushchev truly believed that the deal he had made was in the best interests of Castro and Cuba. What Khrushchev failed to grasp was that Castro's revolution was more nationalist than communist. *Patria o muerte*, fatherland or death—the main slogan of the revolution was about nationalism, not communism—and being regarded or treated as puppets of another great power was the worst thing that Castro and his supporters could imagine.

A few days earlier, on the morning of October 26, Kennedy's ExCom had discussed instructions to the US ambassador in Brazil to use that country's diplomatic channels to drive a wedge between Castro and Khrushchev. This was to be accomplished by suggestions that Moscow's order for its ships to turn back from the quarantine line and rumors that the USSR was prepared to trade Cuba for concessions in Berlin were reducing Castro to a pawn in the hands of Khrushchev, who was about to betray him. The instructions were never sent to Brazil, and Castro was never approached by the Brazilians. But it now appeared that Castro was drawing a similar conclusion on his own—this at a time when the Americans found a split in the communist camp by no means desirable. Indignation became the driving force of Castro's new attitude toward Moscow, and Khrushchev had to find a way of dealing with a new crisis that he had failed not only to foresee but even fully to comprehend once it materialized.[5]

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ALEKSANDR ALEKSEEV, THE MAN CASTRO TRUSTED TO BE HIS direct channel to Khrushchev, found himself in the middle of the political hurricane that hit Soviet-Cuban relations on October 28. Like his Washington counterpart, Anatoly Dobrynin, Alekseev was at a loss when President Osvaldo Dorticós of Cuba asked him to explain the news. Alekseev, who knew nothing about Khrushchev's letter, told Dorticós not to trust the American radio. Dorticós explained that what he had in mind was the statement broadcast by Soviet radio. It was only a few hours later that Alekseev received a copy of Khrushchev's letter to Castro. He immediately tried to deliver it, but the Cuban leader refused to see him.[6]